mess in UP with our development record in Gujarat,' is how Shah summed it up for me later.

Modi's mega rallies in UP were scheduled for each major zonal headquarter across the state, starting with Kanpur in October 2013. Booth workers were given Boleros (a status symbol in many parts of UP) and told to ensure that each rally in their area drew maximum attendance. 'The larger the crowd, the more the chance of creating Modi mania,' was the overarching philosophy.

But how was the message going to be sent out to every village across a vast state, many of which didn't even have proper electricity or access to media? Team Modi deployed 400 GPS-enabled digital raths—similar to the ones that had been used in Rajasthan in the assembly elections (see preceding chapter)—to reach out to what were described to me as 'media dark' villages. As many as 93,000 villages in UP across fifty-one gram panchayats (and around 39,000 villages in Bihar) were identified for video messaging. Some villages were literally small *kasba*s with just fifty voters but even they were not left out.

A sixteen-minute video with the '*Modi aanewala hai*' song and clips of Modi's speeches would be played on the TV screen on the rath, often taking up local issues like *bijli* and contrasting them with the promise of twenty-four-hour power supply as in Gujarat. The BJP/RSS volunteers who accompanied the video van would distribute Modi masks and caps to the children in the village. Every day, the journey of each rath would be monitored by a team of around a hundred IT professionals who would send a daily progress report to the nerve centre in Lucknow. 'We had done it in Rajasthan. Now we needed to scale it up in UP,' says a Team Shah member, sounding like a business executive.

It was becoming clearer by the day that the plump, bearded man from Gujarat had crafted a well-oiled election machine that was ready to roll across the banks of the Ganga. All he needed was one trigger that would sustain the early momentum. If, in Bihar, it was a terror attack, in UP it would be a tragic riot.